

OpenOffice could soon shut down due to a drop in volunteers

OpenOffice, a well-known open source alternative to Microsoft Office, could soon be closed down due to a drastic fall in the number of volunteers. The team behind the office suite is specifically concerned about fixing its security vulnerabilities.



In an email to all OpenOffice developers, Dennis E. Hamilton, a volunteer vice president of the open source project, discussed the current

state of affairs. "I have regularly observed that the Apache OpenOffice project has limited capacity for sustaining the project in an energetic manner. It is also my considered opinion that there is no ready supply of developers who have the capacity, capability and will to supplement the roughly half-dozen volunteers holding the project together," wrote Hamilton.

Originally released in May 2002, OpenOffice has been facing fierce competition from LibreOffice that entered the world of open source in January 2011. One of the prime advantages of LibreOffice over OpenOffice is its regular updates that patch vulnerabilities as well as bring out new features. This is perhaps driving most of the OpenOffice developers to abandon the 14-year-old office suite.

Hamilton does not consider a shutdown as the only solution. However, the retirement of the project has emerged as a 'serious possibility' as some security holes already exist within the suite with no official fix.

"In the case of Apache OpenOffice, needing to disclose security vulnerabilities for which there is no mitigation in an update has become a serious issue," Hamilton wrote in the email.

Before opting for the shutdown, Hamilton's team has sketched out a provisional list of all necessary elements that need to be addressed. The Apache OpenOffice Subversion repository where volunteer developers maintain its code, has already been moved to Apache's 'The Attic' project. Similarly, the source code-based external libraries are likely to be archived.

The current version, OpenOffice 4.1.2, which was released in October last year, is likely to be preserved till the next announcement. But it will not receive any further updates.

RHEL 7.3 beta targets enterprise-scale IoT implementations



Red Hat has released the new beta version of Red Hat Enterprise Linux (RHEL) 7.3. The new platform is aimed at easing enterprise-scale IoT implementations through several new features and improvements over its predecessor, which was launched last November.

To natively enable some affordable connected devices, RHEL 7.3 beta comes with support for Bluetooth LE (low energy). Red Hat has also provided customers with an option to embed the new Linux platform into some high-end industrial controllers using the controller area network (CAN) bus support.

KDE Connect lets you sync Android and Linux

KDE Connect has emerged as a solution that lets you receive Android notifications on your Linux desktop. The app links your Android device with the Linux desktop, enabling a functionality similar to Microsoft's Windows Continuum and Apple's Continuity.

One of the prime advantages of KDE Connect is its compatibility with all Linux desktop environments. This means that you do not need to install KDE Plasma on your system to enable the synchronisation.

You can link your device and Linux PC together using the KDE Connect app. It allows you to access your smartphone's notifications and SMS messages directly on your desktop. You can even respond to them from the large Linux screen. Further, the app offers many other useful features like triggering custom commands and using an Android smartphone as a remote music controller. KDE Connect has been under development for several months. The latest KDE Connect 1.0 adds the SMS-reply feature. The connection between the PC and Android is made over the local network, which avoids the possibility of a server security breach. Notably, KDE Connect uses TLS encryption to ensure a secure connection.

Once the smartphone is connected, you can ignore it completely and depend solely on the Linux PC. On the other hand, the client app can even display PC notifications on the mobile device. There is also the option to trigger your smartphone by performing certain actions on the PC.

You can download the free app from the Google Play store or F-Droid. KDE is also working on a framework for universal apps.

Currently, the KDE Connect client is available for Android and BlackBerry devices. However, its community is in development to build native support for the iPhone in the upcoming version.